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A STUDY ON EMPLOYMENT PROFILE OF PERSONS WITH DISABILITIES (PWDs) IN SELECTED REGIONS IN THE PHILIPPINES

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Institute for Labor Studies

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ABBREVIATIONS

BPO	Business Process Outsourcing
BWSC	Bureau of Workers with Special Concerns
CDC	Clark Development Corporation
CFC	Clark Freeport Zone
CPH	Census of Population and Housing
CRPD	Convention on the Rights of Person with Disabilities
DepEd	Department of Education
DOLE	Department of Labor and Employment
DSWD	Department of Social Welfare and Development
EO	Executive Order
ESCAP	Economic and Social Commission for Asia and the Pacific
ICSO	International Standards Classification of Occupations
ILO	International Labour Organisation
IPs	Indigenous People
MDGs	Millennium Development Goals
NGOs	Non-Government Organizations
NSO	National Statistics Office
NVRC	National Vocational Rehabilitation Center
PESO	Public Employment Service Office
PIDS	Philippine Institute for Development Studies
PWDs	Persons with Disabilities
R.A.	Republic Act
ROs	Regional Offices
SDGs	Sustainable Development Goals
TESDA	Technical Education and Skills Development Authority
TWH	Tahanang Walang Hagdanan, Inc.
UN	United Nation
VocTech	Vocational Technical
WPA	World Programme of Action

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ABSTRACT

Persons with disabilities (PWDs) comprised one-sixth or 15% of the world's population. About 785 million men and women with disabilities or 80 percent were of working age. In the Philippines, of the 92.1 million household population, around 1.4 million or 1.57% had disability, based on the 2010 Census of Population and Housing. Moreover, PWDs were among the vulnerable groups who needed utmost attention from the government.

This research provides an employment profile of PWDs in selected regions in the Philippines. Using quota sampling, a total of 150 employed PWDs in National Capital region (NCR), Region IV-A (CALABARZON) and III (Central Luzon) were selected and interviewed to determine their demographic profile, employment history, sources of income, trainings acquired, and job search experiences.

Key findings of the study are the following: (a) the leading occupations among PWDs are: health associate professionals (e.g. masseurs), elementary occupations (e.g. manufacturing laborers, cleaners, helpers) and clerical office works; (b) education and training are critical factors for securing a decent and satisfying job; (c) PWDs usually rely on their friends and family, training institutions and PWD organization in job search; (d) there are companies that mainstream the employment of the PWDs; (e) non-government organizations play a significant role in ensuring the smooth transition of PWDs into formal employment; and (f) there is a need for strict implementation of laws and policies in providing PWDs with equal employment opportunities.

I. INTRODUCTION

The International Labour Organization (ILO) estimates that one billion, or 15 percent of the world's population are persons with disabilities (PWDs). About 785 million men and women with disabilities or 80 percent are of working age. Worldwide, PWDs are successfully working in various industries and has gainful employment. They are either entrepreneurs, professionals, technicians, clerical support workers, service workers, trade-related workers, and skilled workers. Almost all jobs can be performed by someone with disability, given the right environment and assistance. However, the right of PWDs to decent work is frequently neglected. Several studies have documented that working age PWDs often experience higher rates of unemployment, significantly lower employment rates and limited economic activity leading them into poverty and at greater risk of insufficient social protection.

Article 27 of United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCRPD) recognizes "the right of persons with disabilities to work, on an equal basis with others; this includes the right to the opportunity to gain a living by work freely chosen or accepted in a labor market and work environment that is open, inclusive, and accessible to persons with disabilities." Furthermore, the Convention "prohibits discrimination on the basis of disability with regard to all matters concerning all forms of employment, including conditions of recruitment, hiring and employment, continuance of employment, career advancement and safe and healthy working conditions."

During the 9th Session of the Conference of States Parties to the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (2016), the overarching theme is "Implementing the 2030 Development Agenda for All Persons with Disabilities: Leaving no one behind." ILO, together with stakeholders and partners, organized a side event on the different global and national initiatives that seek to promote private sector employment of PWDs in developing countries. Decent work is highlighted as an integral link to the reduction of inequalities and empowerment of PWDs. Furthermore, the Guide for Business on the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities that is currently developed is a useful tool for promoting decent employment of PWDs.

The Philippines has a long-standing commitment in promoting social justice and achieving decent work for people with disabilities. The Philippines has sponsored the Third Committee Resolution entitled "Realizing the Millennium Development Goals and Other Internationally Agreed Development Goals for Persons with Disabilities Towards 2015 and Beyond." The Resolution aims to strengthen efforts to ensure accessibility for and inclusion of PWDs in all aspects of development, and mainstream their rights in the development agenda beyond 2015.

Furthermore, participation and contribution of PWDs are taken into consideration in the national development effort towards the goal of inclusive growth. This is evident in the Philippines vision of "prosperity and predominantly middle-class society where no one is poor" under the Ambisyon 2040 and with the Department of Labor and Employment (DOLE) 8-Point Platform and Policy Agenda anchored on the promotion of employment and human resource development and ensuring workers' protection and welfare.

Research Problems

Generally, the study aims to create an employment profile of PWDs in selected regions in the Philippines. Specifically, the study intends to answer the following questions:

1. What are the employment characteristics of PWDs?
2. What are the policies that support employment of PWDs both in international and national levels?
3. What are the key factors that contribute to the employability of PWDs?
4. What are the policy recommendations to provide PWDs with decent and productive employment?

Objectives of the Study

The study aims to look at the employment profile of PWDs in selected regions in the Philippines. It intends to achieve the following objectives:

1. To present the employment characteristics of PWDs;
2. To document national laws or policies the support employment of PWDs;
3. To identify the factors that contribute to the employability of PWDs; and
4. To recommend policy options that could provide decent and productive employment for PWDs.

Concepts

For common understanding, the following definitions are used in this study:

1. Persons with Disability (PWD) or Disabled Persons are those suffering from restriction of different abilities, as a result of a mental, physical or sensory impairment, to perform an activity in the manner or within the range considered normal for a human being (Section 4 [a] of Republic Act No. 7277 or "Magna Carta for Disabled Persons").

2. Disability shall mean (1) a physical or mental impairment that substantially limits one or more psychological, physiological or anatomical function of an

individual or activities of such individual; (2) a record of such an impairment; or (3) being regarded as having such an impairment (Section 4 [c] of Republic Act No. 7277 or "Magna Carta for Disabled Persons").

3. Employability shall mean as "portable competencies and qualifications that enhance an individual's capacity to make use of the education and training opportunities available in order to secure and retain decent work, to progress within the enterprise and between jobs, and to cope with changing technology and labour market conditions" (ILO 2013).

4. Decent work involved opportunities that is productive, delivers a fair income, security in the workplace and social protection for families, prospects for personal development and social integration, and freedom for people to express their concerns and participate in decision-making (ILO 2012).

Significance of the Study

In 2012, the Institute for Labor Studies (ILS) conducted a study entitled, Employment Mainstreaming of Workers with Disability. Moreover, a technical learning session was conducted to discuss the salient features of Republic Act No. 7277 or "Magna Carta for Disabled Persons" in 2015. From these initiatives, this study is significant on the following aspects: (1) valuable information to contribute in the existing labor and employment data on PWDs; (2) increased awareness on the employment challenges of PWDs; and (3) advocacy on the promotion of PWD employment.

Methodology

This study utilized both primary and secondary data gathering. Primary data are gathered through the conduct of survey with employed persons with disability and key informant interviews with stakeholders, while secondary data are gathered through desk research. Desk research involves review of related literature, international conventions, and local laws.

Given the time and resource constraints, a survey on 150 employed PWDs was conducted using quota sampling and a structured questionnaire. The survey was conducted in the top 3 regions with highest number of PWDs based on the Census on Population and Housing (2010) and consultation with National Council on Disability Affairs. These are: 1) Region IV-A or CALABARZON; 2) National Capital Region (NCR); and 3) Region III or Central Luzon. The field survey was conducted in 11 April to 12 June 2016. Structured questionnaires were administered through face-to-face interviews with the targeted respondents. Moreover, there are case studies on PWD experiences in job search in relation to training, NGOs as social partners, and companies mainstreaming PWD employment.

II. PWDs AND SOCIAL INCLUSION

PWDs are among the vulnerable groups in our society. They are often excluded and denied of their human rights. Social exclusion, low educational attainment, unemployment, low self-esteem, and limited opportunities to participate in social and political life are few of their challenges, which are effects of disability-based discrimination. Under international treaties, PWDs are entitled to exercise their civil, political, social, economic, and cultural rights on an equal basis with others. The principle of the right to equality is the foundation of the rights of individuals with disabilities.

In 2006, the United Nations adopted the Convention of the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (CRPD) and came into force in 2008. The Convention provides a valuable guidance for the development of effective strategies of social inclusion for PWDs. It recognizes the importance of social policies at the national, regional, and international levels to further equalize opportunities. It takes into account the protection and promotion of the human rights of PWDs in all policies and programs. More importantly, it promotes full and effective participation and inclusion in the society. According to Louise Arbour, former United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights, "the celebration of diversity and the empowerment of the individual are essential human rights messages. The Convention embodies and clearly conveys these messages by envisaging a fully active role in society for person with disabilities." However, before the adoption of this "comprehensive and integral convention", there are other international legal instruments and policy initiatives that contained and confirmed such rights of PWDs.

In 1975, the United Nations General Assembly made a declaration on the rights of disabled persons. The Declaration on the Rights of Disabled Persons affirmed that disabled persons have the same civil and political rights as other people, as well as right to education, vocational training, counselling and placement services, and other services that will enable them to develop their capabilities and skills and will hasten the process of their social integration or reintegration. A year later, the UN General Assembly proclaimed 1981 as the International Year of Disabled Persons, with the theme "full participation and equality." Member states were called for a plan of action at the national, regional, and international levels, with an emphasis on equalization of opportunities, rehabilitation, and prevention of disabilities. Other objectives of the year included: increasing public awareness; understanding and acceptance of PWDs; and encouraging PWDs to organize themselves to improve their situation.

In 1982, the UN General Assembly stressed the promotion of effective measures for prevention of disability, rehabilitation, and realization of the goals of full participation of disabled persons in social life and development and of equality with the adoption of World Programme of Action (WPA) concerning Disabled Persons. It contains three overall aims: prevention of disability, rehabilitation of disabled persons, and equalization of opportunities. Paragraph 12 of the Programme defines the equalization of opportunities as the "process through which the general system of society, such as the physical and cultural environment, housing and transportation, social and health services, educational

and work opportunities, cultural and social life, including sports and recreational facilities, are made accessible to all". On the same day, the General Assembly also proclaimed the period of 1983-1992 as the UN Decade of Disabled Persons and encouraged the member states to utilize this period to implement the WPA.

Building on the results of the UN Decade, the UN Economic and Social Commission for Asia and the Pacific (ESCAP) proclaimed the period 1993 to 2002 as the Asian and Pacific Decade of Disabled Persons (UNESCAP Resolution 48/3). The Asian and Pacific Decade of Disabled Persons, 1993-2002, was a unique initiative of the Asian and Pacific region to take action and focus further specific attention on disability issues. Launched in 1992 in Beijing, China, the primary focus and goal of the Decade Action was the expansion of opportunities for the full participation of people with disabilities in the society and their equality in the development process.

In 2002, governments in the Asian and Pacific region agreed on the extension of the Asian and Pacific Decade of Disabled Persons, 1993-2002, for another decade, 2003-2012. Since then, a number of initiatives have been launched in line with the extended Decade. Among them was the Biwako Millennium Framework for Action towards an Inclusive, Barrier-free and Rights-based Society in Asia and the Pacific as the defining policy guideline for the new Decade. The thrust of the new Decade is to fully implement the paradigm shift from a charity-based approach to a rights-based or human rights approach to the full range of disability concerns in the region. The regional framework for action identifies seven areas for priority action in the new decade. These areas are the following: (1) self-help organization of PWDs and related family and parent associations; (2) women with disabilities; (3) early detection, early intervention, and education; (4) training and employment, including self-employment; (5) access to build environments and public transport; (6) access to information and communications, including information, communication, and assistive technologies; and (7) poverty alleviation through capacity-building, social security, and sustainable livelihood programs. The regional framework for action explicitly incorporates the Millennium Development Goals (MDGs) and their relevant targets to ensure that concerns relating to persons with disabilities become an integral part of efforts to achieve the goals. In 2007, the Biwako Plus Five was adopted to further recognize efforts towards an inclusive, barrier-free, and rights-based society for PWDs in the region. It was implemented on the basis of the same principles and policy directions in the Biwako Millennium Framework for Action amplifying the three aspects: (1) Governments must take appropriate measures to devise national strategies and action plans for the Biwako Millennium Framework for Action and Biwako Plus Five; (2) Partnership among different stakeholders should be promoted in all relevant activities (e.g. research, data collection, needs assessment, policy development, implementation, monitoring and evaluation, capacity-building, and awareness-raising; (3) Respect the diversity of PWDs as partners in the decisionmaking process concerning disability, as implementers and evaluators of projects and policies.

Building on the achievements of the past two consecutive Asian and Pacific Decades of Disabled Persons (1993-2002 and 2003-2012), full realization of the rights of PWDs and disability-inclusive development is being promoted in the new Decade. During the Final Review of the Implementation of the Asian and Pacific Decade of Disabled Persons, 2003-2012 in Incheon, South Korea, the High-level Intergovernmental Meeting adopted the Ministerial Declaration on the Asian and Pacific Decade of Persons with Disabilities, 2013–2022, and the Incheon Strategy to "Make the Right Real" for Persons with Disabilities in Asia and the Pacific. Another pioneering framework at the regional level, the Incheon Strategy provides the Asian and Pacific region, and the world, with the first set of regionally-agreed disability-inclusive development goals.

The Incheon Strategy builds on the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities and the Biwako Millennium Framework for Action and Biwako Plus Five. Adopted in 2012, the Incheon Strategy aims to accelerate actions to promote disability-inclusive development and implementation of the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities in Asia and the Pacific region. It is composed of 10 interrelated goals similar to the structure of MDGs:

- Goal 1: Reduce poverty and enhance work and employment prospects;
- Goal 2: Promote participation in political processes and decision-making;
- Goal 3: Enhance access to the physical environment, public transportation, knowledge, information and communication;
- Goal 4: Strengthen social protection;
- Goal 5: Expand early intervention and education of children with disabilities;
- Goal 6: Ensure gender equality and women's empowerment;
- Goal 7: Ensure disability-inclusive disaster risk reduction;
- Goal 8: Improve the reliability and comparability of disability data;
- Goal 9: Accelerate the ratification and implementation of the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities and harmonization of national legislation with the Convention; and
- Goal 10: Advance sub regional, regional and interregional cooperation.

III. PWDs AND THE PRINCIPLE OF EQUALITY

Social justice is at the core of ILO's mandate. Thus, ILO strongly promotes decent and productive work opportunities for men and women with disabilities. One of the earliest and important instruments in relation to PWDs is the Vocational Rehabilitation (Disabled) Recommendation, 1955 (No. 99). The Recommendation recognizes the importance of PWD rehabilitation to meet their employment needs. Consequently, it acknowledges the importance of restoring PWD's working ability by combining into one coordinated process their medical, psychological, social, educational, vocational guidance, vocational training, and placement services, including follow-up.

In 1958, the Discrimination (Employment and Occupation) Convention (No. 111) and its accompanying Recommendation (No. 111) provided the adoption of a national policy designed to promote equality of opportunities and treatment, with a view to eliminating discrimination in respect of employment and occupation. Although the previous Recommendation did not specifically include this particular instrument, Convention No. 111 makes "special measures of protection or assistance" in the case of disabled persons. Article 5 states that, "any Member may, after consultation with representative employers' and workers' organizations, where such exist, determine that other special measures designed to meet the particular requirements of persons who, for reasons such as sex, age, disablement, family responsibilities or social or cultural status, are generally recognized to require special protection or assistance, shall not be deemed to be discrimination." Furthermore, the Convention provides additional grounds of discrimination after consultation with representative employers' and workers' organizations (Article 1(1)(b)).

Moreover, Article 13 of Convention concerning Invalidity, Old Age and Survivors' Benefits, 1967 (No. 128) reflected the ILO's interest of workers with disabilities. It states that ratifying Members must provide rehabilitation services designed to prepare a disabled person wherever possible for the resumption of his previous activity, or the most suitable alternative gainful activity, having regard to aptitude and capacity as well as take measures to further the placement of disabled persons in suitable employment.

In 1983, the Convention on Vocational Rehabilitation and Employment (Disabled Persons) (No. 159) and Recommendation (No. 168) was adopted which served as the basis for all national legislation and practice concerning vocational guidance, vocational training, and placement of disabled persons. To further implement the provision of existing ILO standards to promote decent work for PWDs, the ILO Code of Practice on Managing Disability in the Workplace has been drawn to guide employers to adopt a positive strategy in managing disability-related issues in the workplace. Based on the international instruments and initiatives, the contents of the code are designed to promote safe and healthy employment of all PWDs.

IV. PWDs AND POST-2015 AGENDA

For the past decades, mainstreaming the disability agenda in internationally-agreed development goals has been on the forefront. Although the MDGs did not sufficiently included the disability / PWD agenda, the new 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) provided significant opportunities for PWDs. In September 2015, world leaders adopted the 17 new SDGs and taking it forward over the next 15 years. The SDGs aimed to build on the work of the MDGs, which is composed of 17 goals and 169 targets to eradicate poverty, fight inequality, and tackle climate change. According to UN Secretary General Ban Ki-moon, the new agenda is a universal, integrated, and transformative vision for a better world.

In reference to the PWDs, disability is specifically referenced in five of the 17 SDGs in parts related to education, growth, and employment, inequality, accessibility of human settlements and data collection and monitoring. The following are the disability-inclusive goals of SDGs:

Table 1. Disability-inclusive Goals of SDGs

SDG	Disability-inclusive Goal	Specific Target
Goal 4: Quality Education **"Ensure inclusive and equitable quality education and promotion of life-long learning opportunities for all."**	Guaranteeing equal and accessible education by building inclusive learning environments and providing the needed assistance for persons with disabilities.	**Target 4.5.** By 2030, eliminate gender disparities in education and ensure equal access to all levels of education and vocational training for the vulnerable, including persons with disabilities, indigenous peoples and children in vulnerable situations.
Goal 8: Decent Work and Economic Growth **"Promote sustained, inclusive and sustainable economic growth, full and productive employment and decent work for all."**	Promoting inclusive economic growth, full and productive employment allowing persons with disabilities to fully access the job market.	**Target 8.5**. By 2030, achieve full and productive employment and decent work for all women and men, including for young people and persons with disabilities, and equal pay for work of equal value.
Goal 10: Reduced Inequalities **"Reduce inequality within and among countries."**	Emphasizing the social, economic and political inclusion of persons with disabilities.	**Target 10.2**. By 2030, empower and promote the social, economic and political inclusion of all, irrespective of age, sex, disability, race, ethnicity, origin, religion or economic or other status.
Goal 11: Sustainable Cities and Communities **"Make cities and human settlements inclusive, safe, resilient and sustainable."**	Creating accessible cities and water resources, affordable, accessible and sustainable transport systems, providing universal access to safe, inclusive, accessible, and green public spaces	**Target 11.2**. By 2030, provide access to safe, affordable, accessible and sustainable transport systems for all, improving road safety, notably by expanding public transport, with special attention to the needs of

SDG	Disability-inclusive Goal	Specific Target
		those in vulnerable situations, women, children, persons with disabilities and older persons. **Target 11.7.** By 2030, provide universal access to safe, inclusive and accessible, green and public spaces, in particular for women and children, older persons and persons with disabilities
Goal 17: Partnership for the Goals **"Strengthen the means of implementation and revitalize the global partnership for sustainable development."**	Underlining the importance of data collection and monitoring of the SDGs, emphasis on disability disaggregated data.	**Target 17.18.** By 2020, enhance capacity-building support to developing countries, including for least developed countries and small island developing States, to increase significantly the availability of high-quality, timely and reliable data disaggregated by income, gender, age, race, ethnicity, migratory status, disability, geographic location and other characteristics relevant in national contexts.

Source: www.un.org (2017)

V. PWDs AND LEGISLATION

International instruments are relevant in recognizing and promoting PWD's rights. The Philippines is one of the countries that ratified the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities and relevant ILO Conventions such as Discrimination (Employment and Occupation) (No. 111) and Vocational Rehabilitation and Employment (Disabled Persons) (No. 159) and its accompanying Recommendation that sets standards in promoting the rights of PWDs. Legislation at country level is fundamental and remains one of the most effective means of facilitating social change and improving the status of disabled persons. In the Philippines, the following are relevant policy initiatives made favorable to PWDs on employment, accessibility, and inclusive growth:

Table 2. Policy Initiatives on PWDs in the Philippines

A. On employment

Law/Policy	Description and Provision
Republic Act No. 10524 or "An Act Expanding the Positions Reserved for Persons with Disability, amending for the Purpose Republic Act No. 7277, as Amended, Otherwise Known as the Magna Carta for Persons with Disability"	In 2013, Republic Act (RA) No. 10524 amended Section 5 of RA 7277 by mandating "at least one percent (1%) of all positions in all government agencies, offices or corporal ions shall be reserved for persons with disability: *Provided,* that private corporations with more than one hundred (100) employees are encouraged to reserve at least one percent (1%) of all positions for persons with disability."
Executive Order No. 261	Signed in 1995, this EO called for the creation of an Inter-Agency Committee on Employment Promotion, Protection and Rehabilitation of PWDs which is tasked to coordinate and monitor the implementation of and compliance with the employment provisions of the Magna Carta for Disabled Persons, and other relevant law.
Republic Act No. 7277 or the "Magna Carta for Disabled Persons"	In 1992, the Magna Carta for Disabled Persons was enacted allowing the full integration differently-abled persons into the mainstream of society. The State must adopt policies ensuring the rehabilitation, self-development and self-reliance of disabled persons. The skills and potentials must enable the PWDs to compete favorably for available opportunities. Section 5 provides equal opportunity for employment for disabled persons. It further sates that a qualified disabled employee shall be subject to the same terms and conditions of employment and the same compensation, privileges, benefits, incentives and allowances as a qualified able-bodied person. Moreover, five percent (5%) of all casual, emergency and contractual positions in the Department of Social Welfare and Development; Health; Education, Culture and Sports; and other government agencies, offices or corporations engaged in social development shall be reserved for disabled persons.

Republic Act No. 1179 or the "Vocational Rehabilitation Act"	In 1952, this Act allows the creation of a Vocational Rehabilitation Office which provides vocational rehabilitation services to blind and other disabled persons to prepare them for suitable employment. Moreover, the Vocational Rehabilitation Office must adopt and maintain a plan known as the Vocational Rehabilitation Plan to effect and facilitate the rehabilitation of disable individuals including census and placement of employment opportunities.

Source: Author's compilation

VI. PWDs AND EMPLOYABILITY

The concept of employability plays a crucial role to local, national, and international labor market policy. McQuaid and Lindsay (2005) defined employability as an "individual's characteristics and 'readiness' for work, or upon the factors influencing a person getting into a job, moving jobs or improving their job". Aside from recognizing personal aptitude as defining factor of employability, McQuaid and Lindsay (2005) added that there are other elements that can affect a person's capability to be employed. They categorized these factors into three:

• Individual factors. This include essential attributes, personal competencies, skills and qualification, and knowledge needed to land a job. It also encompasses a person's demographic characteristics such as age, gender, and disability.

• Personal circumstances. This category covers household circumstances such as financial, time and emotional responsibilities to family members, work culture, and access to basic human necessities such as transportation, and financial and social capital.

• External factors. This factor focuses on labor market factors such as level of local and regional demand of jobs, vacancy characteristics, recruitment factors, and availability of employment policy factors.

Meanwhile, ILO (2013) defined employability as "portable competencies and qualifications that enhance an individual's capacity to make use of the education and training opportunities available in order to secure and retain decent work, to progress within the enterprise and between jobs, and to cope with changing technology and labour market conditions". The definition suggests that employability is affected by core skills or employability skills needed to perform specific tasks or duties developed through basic education. There are four types of core skills — learning to learn, communication, teamwork, and problem-solving.

• Learning to learn. This covers the knowledge, skills, and attitudes that enable a person to be equipped for lifelong learning. The core abilities include adaptability, capacity to select the best approach to finish a task, and proficiency in abstract thinking, among others.

• Communication. This involves the capacity to be understood clearly through listening, reading, writing, and observing. It is also the ability to efficiently send across an idea without being misinterpreted.

• Teamwork. This is a skill needed to effectively operate within a group and it involves self-management, acceptance of feedback, accountability, and work ethics within the culture of the group.

• Problem-solving. This is the analytical ability required to address problems appropriately and adapt to the situation immediately. Some of the examples of this skill is creative thinking, assumption testing, problem identification, and planning and organizing, among others.

Meanwhile, Wahat (2011) identified the different factors that contribute to PWDs' career success. These factors are: (1) individual characteristics; (2) person-environment fit factors; and (3) organizational factors.

• Individual-related factors. The person-related factors or individual attributes associated with career success are gender, age, and education. Furthermore, Nabi (1999, as cited by Wahat) found in his study that there is a significant relationship between all individual attributes with career success. This strengthens the relationship between age, gender, education, and ambition with objective career success. However, Hendey and Pascall (2001, as cited by Wahat) posit that special education limits choices discriminates and disabled individuals from experiencing wider range of training and employment opportunities. These denies the PWDs from the exposure of realities. Thus, combined special and mainstream education is proposed to produce better career success for the PWDs.

• Person-Environment Fit factors. These factors highlight the role of the harmonious interaction between individuals and the environment (e.g. work place). This relationship has been proven in past studies. According to Ballout (2007) and Morley (2007), person-job fit and needs-supplies fit perception as important antecedents of career success.

• Organizational factors. Physical barriers remain as major constraints for employed PWDs to be more productive in their work. Towards individual success, access to activities and certain benefits help the individuals to perform better, thus achieve better career outcomes. This include accessible physical work environment and accessibility to the workplace. For PWDs, good inclusive design actually conveys a message that "you are important".

Given all these concepts and relating to PWD employment, there are coordinated approaches leading to promoting access to decent work for PWDs. It involves skills development for PWDs, promotion to business sector on employment of PWDs, and an enabling environment through legislative and policy initiatives for disability inclusion.

VII. RESULTS OF THE SURVEY

Profile

The survey covered a total of 150 employed PWDs covering the regions of NCR, Regions III, and IV. Of these, half (51%) are visually impaired, 12 percent are hearing and speech impaired, and 37 percent are physically impaired. In terms of sex, the sample has almost equal number of male and female respondents. The average age of the sample is 38 years. Majority (37%) of them are within the ages 30 to 39. The mean age for visually impaired is 34, hearing and speech impaired, 40 and physically impaired, 45. Almost equally, respondents were either single or married (Table 3).

Table 3. Basic Profile of Respondents

By Region	Type of Impairment				
	Physical	Visual	Speech/ Hearing	Total	%
NCR	5	29	12	46	31
Region III	3	30	6	39	26
Region IV-A	48	17		65	43
Total	**56**	**76**	**18**	**150**	**100**
By Sex					
Male	17	46	11	74	49
Female	39	30	7	76	51
Total	**56**	**76**	**18**	**150**	**100**
By Civil Status					
Single	25	40	6	71	47
Married	29	32	11	72	48
Separated	1	1		2	2
Widowed	1	3	1	5	3
Total	**56**	**76**	**18**	**150**	**100**
By Age Group					
20-29		25	5	30	20
30-39	16	35	4	55	37
40-49	21	8	1	30	20
50-59	17	8	7	32	21
60 and above	1		1	2	1
Did not indicate	1			1	1
Total	**56**	**76**	**18**	**150**	**100**

Source: Author's compilation

On educational background (Table 4), survey results revealed that respondents have attended college and high school levels of education. Those with physical and visual impairments have the greater probability of completing their high school education than the hearing impaired.[1] For those who attained college levels, most of them took computer studies, management, education, and finance-related courses.

Table 4. Educational Attainment

By Education Level		Type of Impairment				
		Physical	Visual	Speech/ Hearing	Total	%
College	Graduate	21	17		38	25
	Undergraduate	6	7	4	17	11
Voc Tech	Graduate	4	8		12	8
	Undergraduate					
High School	Graduate	18	20	5	43	29
	Undergraduate	3	2	4	9	6
Elementary	Graduate		6	1	7	5
	Undergraduate	1	8	3	12	8
Did not indicate		3	8	1	12	8
Total		56	76	18	150	100

Source: Author's compilation

Aside from educational attainment, respondents were also asked of their skills. ILO defines skills as the ability to carry out the tasks and duties of a given job. Among the respondents, top skills they possess are on massage therapy, cooking/meat processing, and basic computer operation. These skills are also among the popular courses most PWDs take particularly in TESDA. Other skills are sewing (dressmaking/curtain-making), automotive-related, carpentry, and cosmetology (Table 5).

[1] In all impairment groups, more women are educated than men. More than half of the female respondents (74%) with physical impairment have at least attained high school education while only 26 percent in physically-impaired men.

Table 5. Top Skills of PWDs

Skills	n
Massage Therapy	137
Cooking/Meat Processing	73
IT-related/Basic Computer Operation	52
Sewing (Dressmaking/Curtain Making)	25
Driving/Automotive	20
Electronics (Cellphone/Appliance Repair)	11
Carpentry	10
Welding	5
Plumbing	4
Cosmetology (Manicure/Pedicure/Haircut)	4

Source: Author's compilation

Occupations

In terms of primary occupation, half of the respondents are classified under technicians and associate professionals (using the International Standards Classification of Occupations [ISCO-08]). Those occupations include massage therapists and technical support (Business Process Outsourcing or BPO). Twenty-three percent are elementary occupations which include hand packer and packing machine operators. Interestingly, 8 percent of the respondents belong to administrative and commercial managers. Usually, they are managers of organizational units that provide services across organizations. They are operations manager, field supervisors, and officers of cooperative. There are also clerical support workers (14%) which include data entry clerks, general office clerks, and numerical clerks (payroll clerks, bookkeeping clerks); and services and sales worker (3%) which include janitors. The visually-impaired group is composed mainly (88%) of masseurs (Table 6).

Table 6. Current Employment by Classification

Classification	Type of Impairment				
	Physical	Visual	Speech/ Hearing	Total	%
Managers	5	7		12	8
Technicians and Associate Professionals	10	68		78	52
Clerical Support Workers	16		5	21	14
Elementary Occupations	25	1	8	34	23
Sales and Service Workers			5	5	3
Total	**56**	**76**	**18**	**150**	**100**

Source: Author's compilation

Looking at the interrelationships among different levels of education and occupational classifications of PWDs, there is a mismatch between their education level and type of work. Graduates of technical and vocational courses are more closely related to being clerical support workers and technicians and associate professionals. Those with educational attainment of at least high school graduate usually work as sales and service workers. Meanwhile, those who are taking managerial and supervisory positions have finished college education. For those who have college education, most of their courses are on computer, finance, and business management. Generally, most of employed PWDs are under the occupational category of technicians and associate professionals and elementary occupations. However, there are those who attained at least tertiary level education who end up being sales and services workers, which also do not require higher educational degree such as janitors.

By sector, majority of them are employed by private institutions (Table 7). Most of these institutions are PWD organizations that not only provide training and skills but also provide job opportunities. In Tahanang Walang Hagdan, they have metal craft workshop that fabricates and repairs wheelchairs, crutches, cane, school chairs, walker, and other sub-contracted metal works. Metal craft became their flagship income-generating project. In Vibes, massage-trained blind members started putting up massage clinics in malls and later on applied the principles of franchise development to raise additional capital for the expansion of their business without borrowing money from other financial institutions. Later on, members become co-owners of the massage clinics, ensuring future source of income if they can no longer work as a masseur.

Table 7. Current Employment by Sector

By Sector	Type of Impairment				
	Physical	Visual	Speech/ Hearing	Total	%
Public	5		4	9	6
Private	51	76	14	141	94
Total	**56**	**76**	**18**	**150**	**100**

Source: Author's compilation

There are private companies in which part of their corporate social responsibility (CSR) is to hire PWDs. In Lamoiyan Corporation, part of the CSR activities is helping the deaf community. Furthermore, there are economic zones that requires companies to hire PWDs. The Clark Development Corporation (CDC) incorporated in its Lease Agreement and Sub-Lease Approval the condition that Locators/Investors inside Clark Freeport Zone must hire PWDs and Indigenous People (IPs). For government institutions, pursuant to RA 10524, it mandates "at least one percent (1%) of all positions in all government agencies, offices or corporal ions shall be reserved for persons with disability".

All of the respondents are wage/salary workers, either receiving a fixed salary or hired on a daily basis or per piece rate. Majority of the respondents receive a monthly income between PHP 5,000 to PHP 10,000. In terms of employment history, only 31 respondents (21%) indicated their previous employment. Physically impaired are mostly clerks (i.e. encoders, office staff), while visually- and hearing/speech-impaired are mostly laborers and unskilled workers. Usual previous employment are kitchen or household helpers, vendor/sales lady, janitors or construction worker. Monthly income also ranges between PHP 5,000 to PHP 10,000.

Additional Income

Respondents were also asked if they have any additional source of income aside from the monthly wage/salary they received. Only 19 respondents (13%) said that they have additional source of income. All of them are visually-impaired and work as masseur. Aside from working on Vibes Clinics, they also render home massage service. Others are sales agent of cosmetics, ready to wear items and vitamins supplements. There is only one who receives an additional pay as a treasurer of a cooperative. Additional income is usually below PHP 2,000 (Table 8).

Table 8. Additional Income

Do you have other source of income aside from your salary?	Total	%
No, I did not have other source of income	131	87
Yes, I have other source of income	19	13
Total	**150**	**100**
Home service (massage)	15	79
Sales agent	3	11
Others (Officer of a cooperative)	1	5
Total	**19**	**100**

Source: Author's compilation

Job Search

During job search, respondents were asked if there is an external factor that helped them in finding their current employment. External factor is described as individual, group or activity that can impact the ability of a PWD to achieve its goal of finding a job. Majority of the respondents (77%) said that, there is an external factor while only 19 percent said otherwise.

Table 9. External Factor in Job Search

Is there an external factor that helped you in your job search?	Type of Impairment				
	Physical	Visual	Speech/ Hearing	Total	%
Yes, there's an external factor that helped me.	32	69	15	116	77
No, there's no external factor that helped me.	20	5	3	28	19
Did not answer	4	2		6	4
Total	**56**	**76**	**18**	**150**	**100**

Source: Author's compilation

Bulk (38%) of the respondents rely on their friends followed by family and relatives (16%) in their job search. Training institutions (13%) and NGOs (11%) also assisted PWDs through job referrals. Only 10 percent of them or one in every 10 PWDs that job search are through joining job fairs and recruitment agencies (Table 10).

Table 10. Types of External Factor in Job Search

External Factor	Type of Impairment				
	Physical	Visual	Speech/ Hearing	Total	%
Friends	4	37	3	44	38
Family/Relatives	3	11	5	19	16
Training Institutions		15		15	13
NGOs	10	2	1	13	11
Recruitment Agency	5		3	8	7
Others (i.e. walk in applicants; job fair)			2	2	2
Did not answer	10	4	1	15	13
Total	**32**	**69**	**15**	**116**	**100**

Source: Author's compilation

Respondents were also asked if they seek the assistance of Public Employment Service Office (PESO) in job search (Table 11). Republic Act No. 8759 or the PESO Act of 1999 establishes the PESO as an employment service facility to carry out full employment and equality of employment opportunities for all, including PWDs. Unfortunately, majority (86%) of the respondents did not seek assistance from PESO offices in their job search due to their lack of awareness.

Table 11. Assistance from PESO for Employment

Did you seek the assistance of PESO in your job search?	Type of Impairment				
	Physical	Visual	Speech/ Hearing	Total	%
Yes, PESO assisted me.	7	2	3	12	8
No, PESO did not assist me.	47	73	9	129	86
Did not answer	2	1	6	9	6
Total	**56**	**76**	**18**	**150**	**100**

Source: Author's compilation

Lacking awareness on PESO assistance on job search, advertisements are the usual source of PWDs for job vacancies. Information are through radio announcements, newspaper publications or internet postings. Moreover, many of them rely on their friends for job referrals. It is also an interesting result that PWDs do not seek the assistance of formal institutions such as training centers, NGOs, and government offices (i.e. DSWD) in their job search which could be attributed to their lack of awareness (Table 12).

Table 12. Source of Information for Job Vacancies

Source of Information on Job Vacancies	Type of Impairment				
	Physical	Visual	Speech/ Hearing	Total	%
Advertisements (e.g. Radio, Newspaper, Internet)	32	10	3	45	30
Friends	5	28	2	35	23
Family/Relatives	1	3	3	7	5
Training Institutions		2	1	3	2
NGOs		2		2	1
Government Agencies (e.g. DSWD)		1		1	1
Others (walk in applicants; job fairs)	5	10	9	24	16
Did not answer	13	20		33	22
Total	**56**	**76**	**18**	**150**	**100**

Source: Author's compilation

During job search, majority of the respondents (73%) encountered problems. Most commonly encountered difficulty is discrimination or being ignored. Also, businesses have apprehension on hiring PWDs, compounded by lack of job designs for them. Moreover, lack of education or lower educational attainment and mobility problems (lack of infrastructures) also contribute to limited opportunities for PWDs (Table 13).

Table 13. Difficulty in Job Search

Did you experience difficulty during job search?	Type of Impairment				
	Physical	Visual	Speech/ Hearing	Total	%
Yes, I experienced difficulty.	47	49	14	110	73
No, I did not experience difficulty.	9	27	4	40	27
Total	**56**	**76**	**18**	**150**	**100**

Source: Author's compilation

Training

Training is job related and needs based. It is the acquisition of knowledge and competencies to improve one's capacity, capability, productivity, and performance. To determine the influence of training on job search and current job, respondents were grouped based on their employers. Majority of them (82%) are employed through organizations which advocates equal opportunities for PWDs. There are Vibes massage clinics which owned and managed by blind massage therapists, while Tahanang Walang Hagdan had livelihood projects that include manufacturing wheelchairs, educational toys, bags and other novelty items, and assemble packaging items (Table 14).

Table 14. Type of Employer of PWDs

Employer	Type of Impairment				
	Physical	Visual	Speech/ Hearing	Total	%
Government agency	5		4	9	6
Private company	3	1	14	18	12
NGO (i.e. PWD organization)	48	75		123	82
Total	**56**	**76**	**18**	**150**	**100**

Source: Author's compilation

For public and private employees, all of them (27 respondents) did not take any training for skills development to assist them in their job search (Table 15). Most of them were placed on their jobs and then training comes afterward. By job search duration, most of them took a week or month to find a job. Moreover, it is an interesting trend that their source of information for job opportunities are advertisements and job fairs. Another interesting result is that most of them have regular jobs (permanent position) as clerks, production staff, or utility workers.

Table 15. Training for Job Search (Government and Private Company Employees)

Did you undergo training to assist you in your job search?	Type of Impairment				
	Physical	Visual	Speech/ Hearing	Total	%
Yes, I took some training.					
No, I did not take some training.	8	1	16	25	92
Did not answer			2	2	8
Total	**8**	**1**	**18**	**27**	**100**

Source: Author's compilation

For those employed by NGOs, majority (75%) of had some training. For visually-impaired, before they became blind masseurs, they underwent training in massage therapy either in Vibes, TESDA, DSWD's National Vocational Rehabilitation Center or special schools for the blind. Vibes started as an association of the blind to uplift the economic conditions of those visually-impaired. Realizing that training is not enough to gain employment, they started to train other visually-impaired and set-up massage clinics in strategic locations. Despite their disability, they also become entrepreneurs. Now, the organization does not only provide work opportunities for the blind members, but also extended the opportunity to their abled family members and dependents, working as receptionists, administrative officers, bookkeeper, customer relations officer, service crew, utility and other office workers (Table 16).

Meanwhile, Tahanang Walang Hagdan started as a rehabilitation center for physically-impaired. Like Vibes, there is difficulty of mainstreaming trained PWDs in open employment. To respond to the growing needs of PWDs looking for gainful employment, they included skills workshop and started putting-up a metal craft workshop that fabricates and repairs wheelchairs, crutches, cane, school chairs, walker, and other sub-contracted metal works. Metal craft became their flagship income generating project.

Table 16. Training for Job Search (NGO Employees)

Did you undergo training to assist you in your job search?	Type of Impairment				
	Physical	Visual	Speech/ Hearing	Total	%
Yes, I took some training.	20	75		95	75
No, I did not take some training.	28			28	25
Did not answer					
Total	**48**	**75**	**0**	**123**	**100**

Source: Author's compilation

Majority of those who underwent some training (75%) said that it is useful (Table 17). They used it for skills certification (50), promotion (2) and skills upgrading (2). However, it is an interesting trend that there are respondents who took them less than a month to more than a year in job search duration. On job opportunities, the main source of information is through friends, advertisements (internet, radio, newspaper) and job fairs.

Table 17. Usefulness of Training

Do you think that your training is useful?	Type of Impairment				
	Physical	Visual	Speech/ Hearing	Total	%
Yes, it is useful.	15	56		71	74
No, it is not useful.	5	19		24	26
Did not answer					
Total	**20**	**75**		**95**	**100**

Source: Author's compilation

VIII. CASE STUDIES

To demonstrate the experiences of PWDs in their job search and companies employing PWDs, case studies were presented on the following areas: (a) skills and entrepreneurship development for PWDs; and (b) mainstreaming PWD employment.

Case Study 1: From Freelance Masseur to Entrepreneurs

Lorenzo I. Jimeno is the current Executive Director of Ka Vibes, a SEC-registered stock corporation which manages the economic activities of VIBES Massage. He got totally blind due to illness when he was 3 years old. Since high school to college, he worked as a massage therapist to support his studies. Unfortunately, he only finished 2nd year college taking up BS Business Administration in Philippine Women's University.

Since his teenage years, Lorenzo worked as masseur. He got his formal training in massage therapy from the National Vocational Rehabilitation Center (NVRC). He was one of the trainees of Mr. Dante Tiosan, founder of VIBES in 1992. Aside from massage therapy, he also studied piano through a foundation for visually impaired in Sta. Mesa, Manila. Prior on his work in VIBES, he worked in several massage clinics. However, his employment is short-lived due to low salary or management issues. In 1995, he became an in-house musician in a restaurant. He earned an average of PHP 1,000 a day. In 2001, he worked again as massage therapist. In 2005, he started working in Vibes and occasionally as a musician. In Vibes, he manages Vibes Massage Clinics in Starmall and Festival Mall in Alabang. During this time, he also earned his licensure as a massage therapist from the Department of Health. He also took some training in computer operations in Vibes. Because of his extensive experience in managing Vibes clinics and expertise in massage therapy, Lorenzo was appointed as Executive Director of Ka Vibes. Ka Vibes Corporation acts as the franchisor with the primary objective of selling franchises of Vibes Massage Clinics. Currently, there are 56 franchisees of Vibes Massage Clinics operating in various malls, where 45 are owned and managed by almost 300 blind massage therapists and 11 were owned by sighted regular customers. Now, aside from his earnings and benefits as a regular therapist, he receives incentives as part of the management.

When asked of his experience in applying jobs, he said that he did not experience difficulty and been easily hired because of his skills and training. Given the limited opportunities for PWDs, he said that Vibes has been helpful to give them employment and be productive. Vibes has set up massage training centers, offers employment through their clinics and franchises and even engage them in social enterprising activities for the visually impaired persons.

Case Study 2: Mainstreaming PWD Employment in the BPO industry

Unknown to many, PWDs have found gainful employment in the BPO industry. For instance, Judith Carbungco, a PWD with physical impairment, has worked for 8 years in IQoR 3 in Clark, Pampanga as document analyst. Another one is Ivy Ubungen who works also with IQoR for 6 years and now a senior call center agent. Through hard work and determination, they are now good provider for their families.

Both of them have completed tertiary level of education. Ivy is a BS Radiologic Technology Graduate while Judith complete her secretarial course. For both of them, their status as PWD mattered much less than their capacity, talent, and skill as a BPO employee. The industry opened its door and continued to give them rewarding and stable employment. The company provided them with training on jobs relating to IT and they have emerged as integral part of productive IT and BPO workforce.

Aside from the training and family support, legislation within the CDC has also contributed in mainstreaming employment for PWDs. CSR programs are consciously undertaken bearing in mind CDC's responsibility to the physically-challenged individuals under the Magna Carta for Persons with Disabilities (R.A. 9442). CDC incorporated in its Lease Agreement and Sub-Lease Approval the condition that Locators/Investors inside Clark Freeport Zone must hire Persons with Disability (PWD) and Indigenous People (IPs). Moreover, jobs fair exclusively for PWDS and IPs were also conducted.

Case Study 3: Lamoiyan: Providing Equal Opportunities for PWDs

Lamoiyan Corporation, a manufacturing company of oral, household, and personal care products are employing PWDs, particularly deaf-mutes. In an interview, Dr. Cecilio Pedro, CEO and President, said that the deaf-mutes are neglected in the communities, but when properly inspired and motivated, they can be very efficient.

The company hires deaf-mute in their factory, except for the supervisory work which needs hearing. At present, there are 25 deaf-mute factory employees who are filling operators, endliners, and checkers. In Lamoiyan, non deaf-mute employees adjusted their skills to be able to communicate with the deaf. They have a sign language class regularly for the hearing, and the supervisors, most if not all, can sign with the hearing-impared. Moreover, deaf-mute workers also received the same compensation and benefits like any regular employees of the company. These benefits are monetary, in-kind (e.g. Christmas grocery, product give aways, birthday treats/lunch), and trainings.

Lamoiyan Corporation not only kept its commitment in providing equal working opportunities to the hearing impaired workers but also strengthen their CSR advocacy by helping the deaf community. The company is supporting deaf schools in Laguna and has partnered with Deaf Evangelistic Alliance Foundation, Inc. which focuses on the education, training, and rehabilitation of the deaf and their communities.

IX. CONCLUSION

Notwithstanding the limited number of respondents, some meaningful insights could be drawn from the study.

Almost all jobs can be performed by persons with disability and given the right environment, they can be productive. Usually, PWDs are either self-employed or employed in the informal economy. However, there are PWDS who have successfully integrated themselves in the formal labor market. Education and training are considered critical factors in gaining employment. Having a good educational background is one of the most important requirements in getting a satisfactory job. Also, high quality skills acquired through training is another pathway that lead to employment. Although occupations available to PWDs are usually simple and routine, training and mainstream programs have developed or restored their capabilities to participate in the competitive labor market. Many organizations have offered vocational skills (e.g. welding, massage therapy, graphics design, crafts related, among others) which has helped to restore the capabilities for those with disabilities. Aside from skills training, organizations also offered core life-skills training, including training in interpersonal skills and management which helps the PWDs adjust to the business environment. More importantly, skills were imparted to these PWDs to become self-reliant.

Laws and regulations affecting employment for PWDs include anti-discrimination laws and affirmative actions. The right to work is a fundamental human right regardless of your physical well-being. Access of PWDs to decent work is important both as an essential right and in terms of economic advantages it brings. Ratified by more than 150 countries including the Philippines, the UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities guarantees the rights of PWDs to mainstream vocational training, employment, and social protection. Work related provisions are reinforced by ILO Vocational Rehabilitation and Employment (Disabled Persons) Convention, 1983 (No. 139) as well as by the Discrimination (Employment and Occupation) Convention, 1958 (No. 111).

In the Philippines, there are laws and policies pertaining to inclusion and employment of PWDs. RA 7277 or the Magna Carta for PWDs requires government organization to reserve a certain percentage of job positions for PWDs. Another provision is the incentives to private employers to ensure gainful employment and ensuring the safety of PWDs within their working environment and public infrastructure are PWD-friendly. Aside from these measures, there is “affirmative action” through issuance of a comprehensive national plan translating disability-related laws and policies into concrete programs, projects, and activities.

Social partners and organizations, as well as employers of PWDs create a supportive environment for disability inclusion. One of the interesting findings is that being a member of a disabled person organization plays an important role, not only in providing training and employment to PWDs, but also in empowering them and improving their perspective in life. NGOs had a significant role to play in forging a symbiotic employer-employee relationship and ensuring that the PWDs made a smooth transition into their roles. Access to their activities and certain benefits help the individuals to perform better and thus achieve better career outcomes. Another interesting pattern is that companies employing PWDs is both a CSR initiative and a Human Resource activity.

X. WAY FORWARD

Employment of PWDs remains a major challenge, partly due to lack of awareness and low organizational priority. However, coordinated approaches are needed between government, employers, and worker's organizations as well as social partners and PWD organizations to promote labor market inclusion of PWDs.

• **Stricter implementation of laws and policies pertaining to employment of PWDs.** RA 7277 or the Magna Carta for the Disabled Persons provides the rights and privileges of PWDs and their integration into the mainstream of the society. The law has certain provisions allotting a certain percentage of positions for PWDs in government organizations. Also, private employers are entitled to incentives to encourage active participation in promoting the welfare of PWDs. Strict observance of these provisions enable the PWDs to job security and inclusion to the labor market.

• **Increase partnership in conducting projects and regular activities catered for PWDs.** Partnership with local government units and PWD organizations in providing training on income-generating activities, vocational skills and rehabilitation can help restore their capabilities. Other training could also include interpersonal skills and coping mechanisms can help PWDs to become self-reliant.

• **Improve information channels on employment and training opportunities for PWDs.** It is important to maintain a complete registry of PWDs for increased collaboration with PWD organizations in exploring livelihood opportunities, disseminating information, and designing a holistic program for PWDs.

• **Ensure social protection of workers including PWDs.** In pursuing the Enhanced Social Protection Operational Framework and Strategy which is envisaged to serve as the overall guide for implementing social protection programs/ interventions and other policies, it must be ensured that social protection systems are fully inclusive of PWDs.

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